

Photographs by PURUSHOTTAM DIWAKAR



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Is the star the victim of a bad boy image or a careless criminal about to get his comeuppance?

they see arrogance tamed.

And therein lies the tragedy of Salman Khan. He is not perceived as a damaged hero as much as a hero who damages. He is not seen as the tragic victim as much as he is the terror who victimises. He is not seen as the little boy who works only to keep the party going but as a calculating criminal whose recklessness is equalled by his callousness. What is an error of judgement in Dutt is a wilful offence in Salman's. Whether it is his 41 midnight calls to Vivek Oberoi, the six hours of non-stop battering of former girlfriend Aishwarya Rai's door, or the drunken outpourings about bhaais and beauties in a national newspaper—this is what media memories are made of. Salman the blackbuck slayer, Salman the killer driver, Salman the binge drinker. The

other Salman, who weeps when he meets his mother at Jodhpur jail, who paints oils and watercolours in his spare time, who gifts a Mercedes to his friend Govinda, is only occasionally leaked to the media. Testaments to his simplicity are usually in multiples but only from loyalists of Brand Salman—if Boney Kapoor says he will simply check out of a five-star hotel which refuses to allow him to stay with his two French Mastiffs, MySon and MyJaan, then Nadiadwala will point to a Rs 20 lakh watch, which he will just take off his wrist and give to a friend who admires it.

Never complain, never explain. That's the golden rule of stardom. Perhaps Salman is a throwback to the old glamour days when the industry was less a business and more one giant joint family, when Dilip Kumar could

TROUBLED HISTORY

1998: POACHING

Is accused in four cases, three under the Wildlife Act 1972 and one under the Arms Act 1959, all while shooting for *Hum Saath Saath Hain*.

CASE 1: Is sentenced to one-year imprisonment in 2006, for killing two chinkaras. His appeal is pending.

CASE 2: In the same year, in a separate case, he is sentenced to five years in jail for killing a chinkara. On August 24, the sessions court upholds his punishment.

CASE 3: Is accused of killing two blackbucks, along with Saif Ali Khan, Tabu, Neelam and Sonali Bendre.

CASE 4: Is accused of carrying arms with expired licence.

2002: HIT AND RUN

■ Salman's Toyota Landcruiser runs over five people in Bandra. While one person dies, four others suffer injuries. Spends 17 days in jail.

■ Chhota Shakeel aide Anjum Phajlani from Dubai claims Salman had agreed to work in *Chori Chori Chupke Chupke* after receiving threats from Shakeel who had allegedly financed the film through Bharat Shah.

2003: PLAYING THE STALKER

Fellow actor Vivek Oberoi holds a press conference accusing Salman of calling him 41 times and of harassing Aishwarya Rai.



2005: DIRTY TALK

A newspaper carries transcripts of phone conversations, said to be



between Salman and Aishwarya Rai, where he is heard talking about his underworld contacts.